

Why Sortition Works: Effort v. Impact

How lottery-selected assemblies eliminate participation barriers and guarantee political outcomes



1. Low Barrier

ELIMINATES FRICTION

- **Civic Lottery:** Stratified random selection matching exact census demographics.
- **Zero Research Burden:** Paid stipends, childcare, and neutral expert testimony provided.
- **Equal Access:** Removes socio-economic obstacles to showing up.

PROVEN MODEL

Oregon CIR (USA): 24 everyday voters convened to review complex ballot measures.



2. Informed Voice

BYPASSES PARTISANSHIP

- **Evidence-Based:** Citizens cross-examine experts and deliberate in small groups.
- **Consensus-Driven:** Moves past binary shouting matches and political outrage.
- **Shielded Environment:** Free from campaign money and special interest pressure.

PROVEN MODEL

Irish Citizens' Assembly: 99 citizens broke 30-year constitutional deadlocks.



3. Direct Impact

CLOSES FEEDBACK LOOP

- **Mandated Pathways:** Tied directly to binding referendums or legislative votes.
- **Official Reach:** Panel findings published directly to millions of voters.
- **Legal Accountability:** Parliament required by law to debate and respond.

PROVEN MODEL

Ostbelgien Council (Belgium): Permanent citizen body embedded in parliament.



Lightning Takeaway: Sortition fixes the civic breakdown by shifting the burden off individual citizens (providing structure, experts, and stipends) and anchoring their input directly into formal policy outcomes.